

MBA: 8109 RESEARCH METHODS



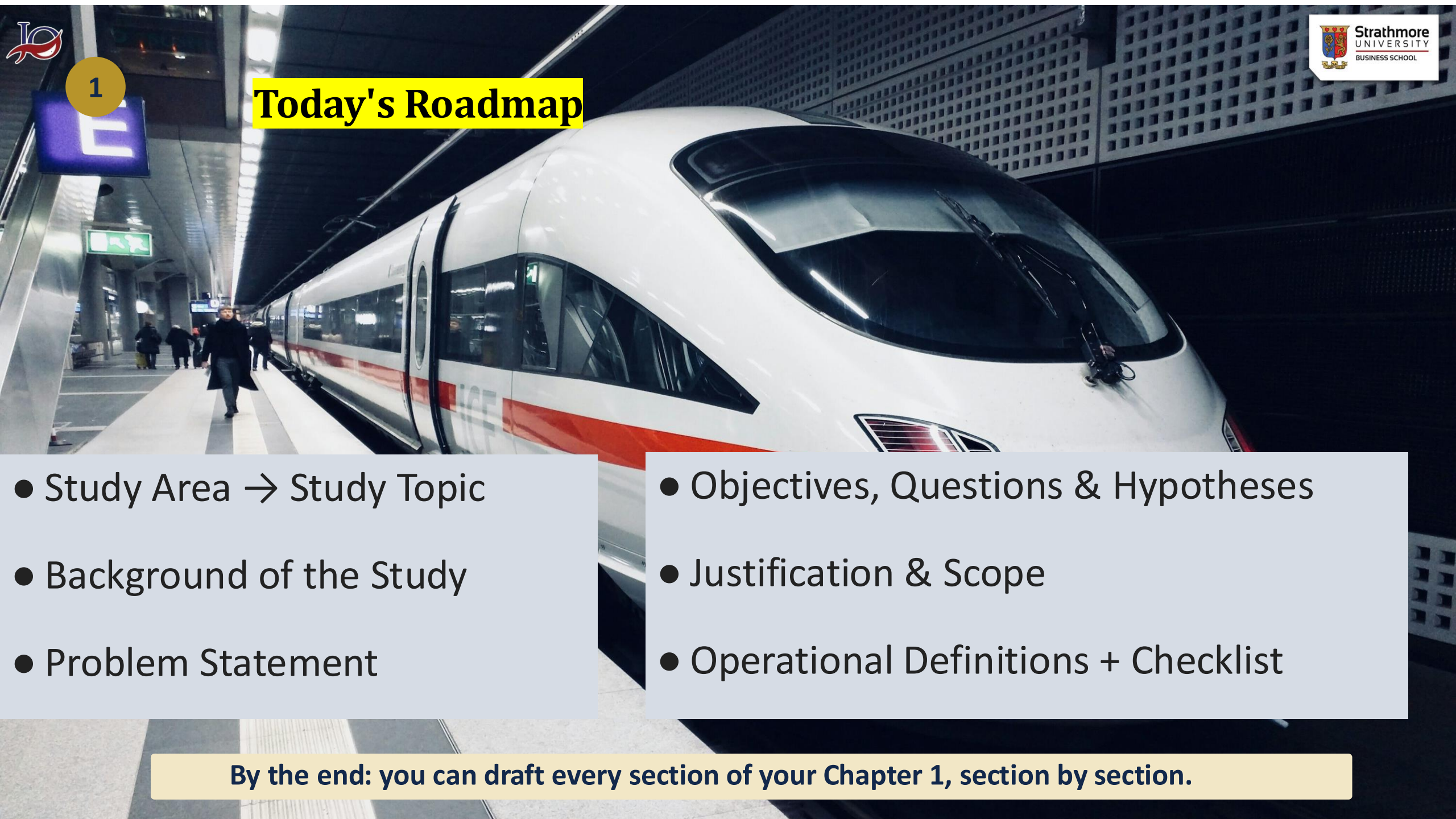
Session 2 — From Study Area To Chapter One

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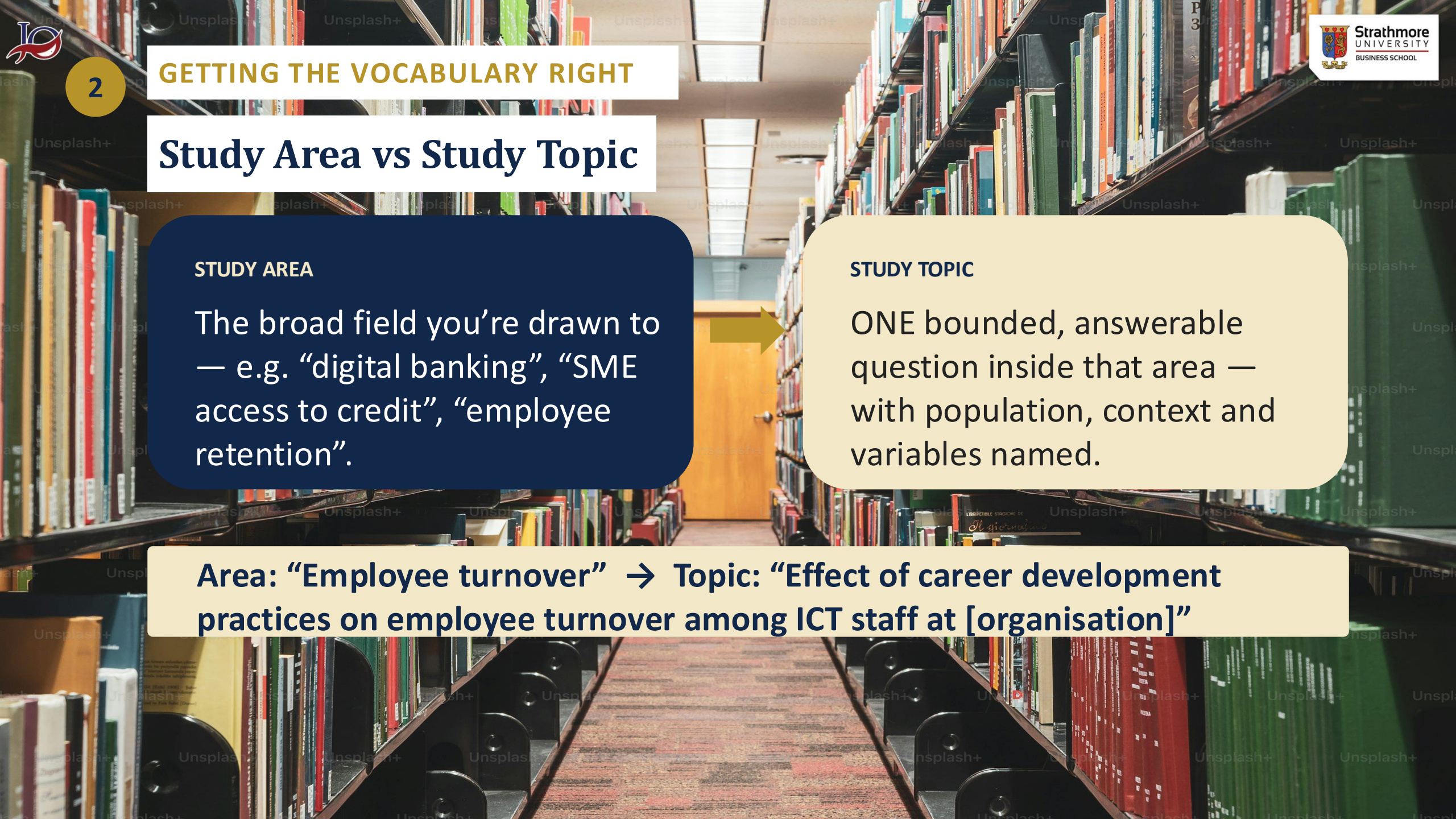


1

Today's Roadmap

- Study Area → Study Topic
- Background of the Study
- Problem Statement
- Objectives, Questions & Hypotheses
- Justification & Scope
- Operational Definitions + Checklist

By the end: you can draft every section of your Chapter 1, section by section.



2

GETTING THE VOCABULARY RIGHT

Study Area vs Study Topic

STUDY AREA

The broad field you're drawn to — e.g. “digital banking”, “SME access to credit”, “employee retention”.



STUDY TOPIC

ONE bounded, answerable question inside that area — with population, context and variables named.

Area: “Employee turnover” → Topic: “Effect of career development practices on employee turnover among ICT staff at [organisation]”



READ THIS BEFORE YOU COMMIT

Why Topic Selection Deserves Your Full Attention

- A weak topic reveals its flaws only after you've invested months in it.
- Supervisor allocation is matched to your topic and its area of expertise.
- Access and ethical issues surface AFTER you've committed — rarely before.
- Restarting mid-way means redoing literature — sometimes redoing ethics clearance too.

The topic you choose in Week 2 is the topic you defend in Month 8. Choose it carefully.

What to Consider When Narrowing Your Area

- Feasibility — doable within your time and access.
- Genuine personal or professional interest.
- A clear contribution — not already conclusively answered.
- Data availability — will people/records really be reachable?
- Fit with your organisation's or sector's realities.
- Alignment with recognised business/management research areas.

Box 2.1 Checklist

Characteristics of a good research idea

Appropriateness

- ✓ Does the idea fit the specifications and meet the standards set by the examining institution?
- ✓ Does the idea contain issues that have a clear link to theory?
- ✓ Are you able to state an overarching research question(s), research aim and research objectives or investigative questions clearly?
- ✓ Will the proposed research be likely to provide fresh insights into this topic?
- ✓ Are the findings likely to be symmetrical: that is, of similar value whatever the outcome?

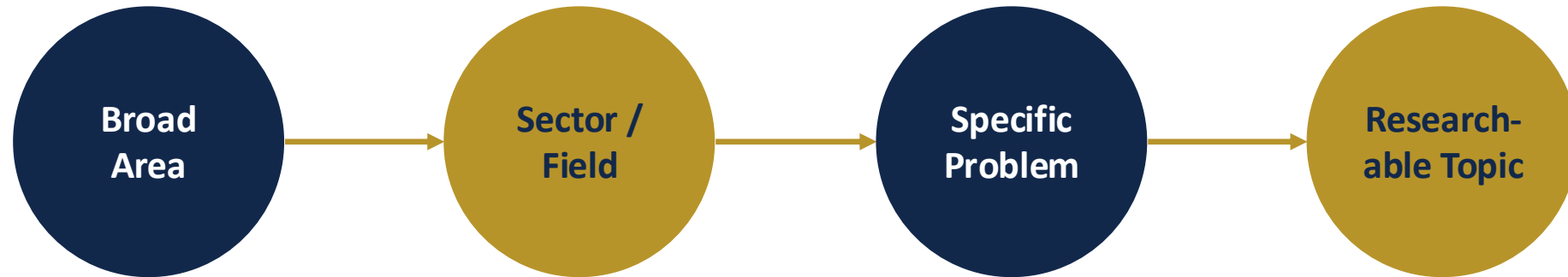
Capability

- ✓ Do you have, or can you develop within the project time frame, the necessary research skills to undertake the research?
- ✓ Is the research achievable within the available time?
- ✓ Is the research achievable within the financial resources that are likely to be available?
- ✓ Are you reasonably certain of being able to gain access to data you are likely to require for this research?

Fulfilment

- ✓ Does the research idea really interest and motivate you?
- ✓ Will the research help towards the achievement of your future aspirations or career goals?

The Narrowing Funnel



Each stage gets narrower — and more specific — than the last. You should be able to name where you are on this line right now.

If you cannot draw your own funnel in 60 seconds, your area is still too broad.

5

RUN THIS TEST ON YOUR OWN TOPIC

Is My Topic Ready?

1 Can I state it in ONE sentence?

2 Can I access the data within my timeline?

3 Has it already been conclusively answered?

4 Is it MBA-level — bounded — not PhD-scale?

Table 2.2 From research idea to overarching research question

Research idea	(Initial) overarching research question	(More focused) overarching research question
Media campaign following product recalls	In what ways can media campaigns be designed to increase consumer trust, value and loyalty in exchange relationships following product recalls?	How does brand equity in media campaigns increase consumer trust, value and loyalty <i>following product recalls</i> ?
Graduate recruitment post pandemic	How have firms responded post pandemic to ensure effective recruitment and selection of graduates?	Can cybervetting predict person environment fit and competence in <i>post-pandemic graduate recruitment</i> ?
Supermarket coupons as a promotional device	To what extent do supermarket coupon promotions influence buyer behaviour?	Does couponing affect buyer motivation in <i>supermarkets</i> ?
Small business start-up funding	To what extent is small business start-up borrowing influenced by the characteristics of the owner?	To what extent are small business start-ups' <i>borrowing decisions</i> influenced by the owners' <i>need for independence</i> ?

Key: **A**bstract concept, Context

Background of the Study: Purpose & Structure



- Purpose: to situate your problem — not to review literature.
- Move Global → Regional → Local, each in its own clear section.
- Weave in scholarly perspective only as context-setting introduction.

THE READER'S FIRST CONTACT WITH YOUR STUDY

Identifying Your Variables in the Background

- Name your key variables explicitly — as they apply in YOUR study. These should be identified from your study topic
- Show how each variable actually behaves or is discussed in your sector. (manifestation in your study)
- This is where your reader first meets the concepts your study will measure AND THE KEY CONSTRUCT THAT WILL BUILD INTO YOUR SPECIFIC OBJECTIVES

A background that never names its variables leaves the reader guessing what the study is actually about.

Variables of the Study: Types and How to Spot Them

INDEPENDENT VARIABLE (IV)

The presumed cause you manipulate.

Spot it: the “effect of ____” half



DEPENDENT VARIABLE (DV)

The outcome that changes in response.

Spot it: the “...on Y” half

MODERATING

Alters the strength or direction of the IV–DV relationship.

Spot it: “depends on...” cues

MEDIATING / INTERVENING

Explains how the IV produces the DV — it sits between them.

Spot it: “through...”, “because of...”

CONTROL

Held constant so it cannot distort the relationship you test.

Spot it: what you hold constant

EXTRANEOUS / CONFOUNDING

Outside your model, yet able to move the DV and mislead you.

Spot it: rival explanations

Name the type, not just the variable — examiners check that your objectives test the relationship you claim.

Introducing the Study: Site, Situation & Sector

- Describe the institution or sector under study, and its operations.
- Clarify the situation that makes this site relevant to your variables.
- Ground the reader in a concrete, real context — never an abstract one.



WHAT EXAMINERS FLAG MOST OFTEN

Background Pitfalls to Avoid

- Citing scholars' views as if writing a literature review, not a background.
- No clear Global → Regional → Local structure or sections.
- Key variables mentioned nowhere in the background.
- Three-line paragraphs instead of fully developed ones.

Every one of these is a direct line item on the Chapter 1 checklist you'll use to self-review (Section G).

Problem Statement: What It Is

WHAT IT IS

The specific gap, tension or unresolved issue your study addresses — named in your own words, in one place.

WHAT IT IS NOT

Not the background. The background sets the stage; the problem statement names the gap that stage exposes.

Fit for purpose: the statement must suit the mode of inquiry you have chosen — qualitative or quantitative.

Positioning a Business Case as a Scholarly Problem

BUSINESS PAIN

A symptom the organisation feels — attrition, defaults, stalled adoption.

EVIDENCE OF A GAP

Cited evidence that the pain persists and is not yet explained.

SCHOLARLY PROBLEM

A variable relationship no one has settled — framed for inquiry, not action.

SAYS THE MANAGER

“Our turnover is too high and HR must fix it this year.”

SAYS THE SCHOLAR

“The effect of career development practices on turnover among ICT staff remains unestablished in this context.”

The test: if the answer is a decision, it is a business case. If the answer is evidence about a relationship, it is a research problem.

Writing the Problem Statement: Four Moves

HOW TO IDENTIFY ONE

- Persistent, documented symptom — not a one-off complaint.
- Conflicting or thin evidence in the literature.
- Data you can realistically reach within your timeline.
- An unexplained relationship — not a missing decision.

THE FOUR MOVES

- 1 CONTEXT** *“In [setting], X matters because...”*
- 2 EVIDENCE** *“Studies show..., yet...”*
- 3 GAP** *“What remains unknown is...”*
- 4 CONSEQUENCE** *“Without this evidence, ...”*

ONE-SENTENCE TEMPLATE

Despite [evidence of the symptom], [the gap] remains unexamined in [context]; this study therefore examines the effect of [IV] on [DV] among [population].

How to Formulate a Problem Statement

1

GAP

Start from a documented gap or contradiction surfaced in your background.

2

STATE

State it in clear, unambiguous, narrow-scope language.

3

SITUATE

Situate it within the literature — show it is a real, evidenced gap, not an assumption.

4

EVIDENCE

Support it with empirical evidence, properly cited within the corpus of literature.

Qualities of a Good Problem Statement

- Clearly and unambiguously stated.
- Narrow in scope — not a whole field's worth of problems.
- Situated within, and supported by, the literature.
- Matched to a qualitative or quantitative approach, and feasible to investigate.

Key Sections of a Problem Statement

- The gap or tension being addressed, stated plainly.
- Evidence that the gap exists — cited, not assumed.
- Why existing knowledge or practice has not yet resolved it.
- A bridge sentence leading into your purpose and objectives.





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SECTION 1.3 OF YOUR CHAPTER ONE

Research Objectives: General & Specific

GENERAL OBJECTIVE

The overall purpose of the study, stated in one sentence.



Specific Objective 1

Specific Objective 2

Specific Objective 3

Measurable steps that together deliver the general objective. Each one resurfaces in your literature review, methodology and findings chapters.

Deriving Specific Objectives from Your Variables

GENERAL OBJECTIVE (WORKED EXAMPLE)

To examine the effect of career development practices on employee turnover among ICT staff at [organisation].

- | | | |
|---|-------------|--|
| 1 | IV → DV | To determine the effect of training opportunities on employee turnover. |
| 2 | IV → DV | To assess the effect of career pathing on employee turnover. |
| 3 | IV → DV | To examine the effect of mentorship on employee turnover. |
| 4 | MODERATING | To establish whether supervisor support moderates the training–turnover relationship. |
| 5 | INTERVENING | To determine whether job satisfaction mediates the career pathing–turnover relationship. |
| 6 | CONFOUNDING | To assess the influence of external pay competitiveness on employee turnover. |

Research Questions: Quality Criteria

- Directly answerable through the data you plan to collect.
- Focused, not broad — one idea per question.
- In sync with, and numbered to match, your objectives.
- Capable of shedding real light on the stated problem.

Table 2.4 Research objective and investigative question criteria

Criterion	Purpose
Transparency (What does it mean?) Specificity (What I am going to do?)	The meaning is clear and unambiguous. The purpose is clear and easily understood, as are the actions required to fulfil it.
Relevance (Why I am going to do this?)	The link to the aim and overarching research question and wider research project is clear.
Interconnectivity (How will it help to complete the research project?)	Taken together as a set, the research objectives and/or investigative questions outline the steps in the research process from its start to its conclusion, without leaving any gaps. In this way, they form a coherent whole.
Answerability (Will this be possible?) (Where shall I obtain data?)	The intended outcome is achievable. Where this relates to data, the nature of the data required will be clear or at least implied.
Measurability (When will it be done?)	The intended outcome will be evident when it has been achieved.

Research Hypotheses: When & How

- Needed for quantitative studies testing a relationship between variables.
- Stated as testable propositions — not phrased as questions.
- Framed in null and/or alternative form, as your design requires.
- Must align exactly with the objectives and variables already named.

Table 2.3 From overarching research question to research aim

Overarching research question	Research aim
How does brand equity in media campaigns increase consumer trust, value and loyalty following product recalls?	. . . to assess the impact of brand equity on consumer trust, value and loyalty relationships in media campaigns following a series of product recalls.
Can cybervetting predict person environment fit and competence in post pandemic graduate recruitment?	. . . to explore and explain the relationship between cybervetting and graduates' person-environment fit and competence in post-pandemic recruitment.
Does couponing affect motivation to purchase products in supermarkets?	. . . to establish the impact of supermarket couponing on buyer motivation.
To what extent are small business start-ups' borrowing decisions influenced by the owners' need for independence?	. . . to examine the extent to which small business start-ups' borrowing decisions are affected by the owners' need for independence.

THE SINGLE MOST-CHECKED ITEM IN CHAPTER ONE

Strong Alignment, Start to Finish



If a reader can't trace a straight line from your problem to your last research question, the alignment has failed.

Justification & Significance of the Study

- Make an explicit case for why this research matters, now.
- Show its contribution to the knowledge base and/or to practice.
- Mirror the structure Strathmore expects in this section — check completed examples.
- Support every claim of importance — don't just assert it.

Scope of the Study

- State clearly what the study covers — and, briefly, what it does not.
- Bound it by population, geography, time period and variables.
- Keep it consistent with what your objectives can realistically deliver.

Operational Definition of Terms

- Define only terms that do not have a commonly understood meaning but key in your study.
- Support each definition with an authoritative, cited source.
- State how the term is specifically used and measured in YOUR study.



Chapter 1 Checklist: Structure, Language & Referencing

- Background moves Global → Regional → Local, in clear, separate sections.
- Key variables are named and applied — not just mentioned in passing.
- The institution or sector and its operations are described.
- The problem is clear, narrow, evidenced and situated in the literature.
- There is strong alignment among problem, purpose, objectives and research questions.
- Every section is numbered with clear levels: 1.2, 1.2.1, 1.2.1.1.
- Paragraphs are fully formed — not three-line fragments.
- Language matches your qualitative/quantitative approach throughout.
- Every claim is referenced in APA — no paragraph left without a citation.
- Checked against Strathmore's own program-specific variations for Chapter 1.

Use the full JO Chapter 1 Checklist as your personal pre-submission audit — every time, not just once.

Recap and Next Steps

COVERED TODAY

Topic selection, background, problem statement, objectives, questions, hypotheses, justification, scope and definitions.

BEFORE NEXT SESSION

Bring a full first-attempt draft of your Background and Problem Statement, objectives, research questions and/ or Hypothesis .

SELF-REVIEW FIRST

Run the Chapter 1 Checklist on your own draft before you bring it — not after.

See you next session — come with a draft, not just a topic.